



From Make in India to Design in India

The DITAA 2026 panel's honesty came from specificity. Nobody argued that India can't innovate; instead which link in the chain is missing, and each named a different one.

For Samaddar the gap is authorship. A product designed elsewhere arrives with its suppliers already fixed, which means the sourcing decision was made before the Indian factory was ever involved.

She pointed to surveillance cameras as proof that standards can drive quality and share together – Indian companies now hold over half that market.

Rajeev Singh's missing link is physical: without domestic display fabrication, the most valuable component of every screen-based product is imported, however much of the rest is assembled locally. His response has been unglamorous –

changed stocking and forecasting policies, on the grounds that the next shock is unpredictable.

Mayank Sinha of Selsmart argued the chain has a back end nobody costs properly. Recycling should not sit outside manufacturing; recovered materials matter only if they are in a usable form.

Jain supplied the timeline. Ten years – and, notably, a number rather than a mood. **d**



SWATI SAMADDAR

Head of Government Affairs and Public Policy, CP Plus

"The biggest opportunity currently in India is not Make in India, but design in India, design for India and design for the world. India has to move from assembling to designing, writing the code for the software which is running each and every appliance, as well as ensuring they are tested for India and for the world... Global supply chains went through multiple upheavals right from COVID. There was the semiconductor supply chain crisis. Then the critical mineral crisis.

And now we are dealing with the memory crisis, along with SoC. If you design here, you define who should be your supplier."



RAJEEV SINGH

Managing Director, BenQ India and South Asia

"In the overall ecosystem, one thing is completely missing, which is the display fab manufacturing. Because display is now an integral part of almost all the devices. And not having a display fab in India, that means a good part of every product still has to be imported into India. That's the one big thing which is yet to happen. We don't believe that when you do make in India, you should make each and every part in India. You should really leverage on the things which are good in India. More importantly, when you have a product which is designed for India."



SANJAY JAIN

Director, ElanPro

"In certain categories, yes. Overall, it is still a long way. The first thing which you start doing is assembling. Then you start trying to do some localisation and move into complete manufacturing. We have done the same. And then you start innovating, designing. In my line, commercial refrigeration, we are doing a lot of backward engineering still because the globe is much, much ahead of us, be it in refrigerant or compressor and other things. In my wisdom, in my views, we are still at least 10 years away from being real innovators and designers overall in the appliances segment."

